



THE GLITZ AND GLAMOUR OF IPL-1 WILL BE MISSED

H.K. RAJASHEKHAR

for five years and keeping the rest of the world rights for \$5 million a year, with built-in escalation clauses. The total value of the BCCI-WSG deal was \$306 million for the first five years and \$612 million for the next five years with the number of teams going up to nine in Season 4 and ten in Season 5. Sony had first option on the next five years as well.

At that point, Modi had declared that it was the "best deal for the IPL and Indian cricket fans", a statement he echoed when he triumphantly announced the revised deal this week. But while on the face of it, Sony had signed the deal with BCCI for \$54 million for the first year, in reality, this included a \$10-million ratings bonus which Sony was to pay to the BCCI only if the average ratings of the tournament exceeded 5 all India. They didn't and there was tension between the BCCI and Sony, which came to a head earlier this year when the BCCI sent two notices to Sony after being unable to twist their arm on parting with the bonus. One notice dealt with the BCCI contesting a contract Sony had signed with Airtel DTH for Rs 35 crore, saying it conflicted with a deal it had signed with Big DTH for Rs 137 crore as an on-ground sponsor. Later in court, the BCCI counsel admitted that Reliance was never an official sponsor. The other notice dealt with the quality of the broadcast, citing among other issues prematurely cutting to breaks, inserting ads during live matches and drowning the commentary with the audio soundtrack.

So on the night of March 14, BCCI terminated its contract with Sony citing "bad qual-



The change in venue does not mean that the competitive spirit would change. Fans across the country will be able to watch on TV. ♣

VIJAY MALLYA, *Owner, Bangalore Royal Challengers*



Our team has a strong South African connection. Our South Africans will have a great impact on establishing our fanbase there. ♣

NITA AMBANI, *Co-owner, Mumbai Indians*

ity of broadcasting in the last IPL season", and at 3 am on March 15, a Sunday, it signed another contract with WSG Mauritius. Sony, or rather its holding company, the Singapore-based Multi-Screen Media, took a hard line then, going to court against this termination of contract, but did not make WSG Mauritius a party to the litigation. Citing lack of jurisdiction, the Bombay High Court said it could not give temporary relief to Sony.

With just days to go before IPL-2 in South Africa, it had left viewers, who had switched from prime time soaps to cricket last year, confused on where they would watch the tournament, despite tempting promos on Set Max building the buzz. But clearly, that was not BCCI's main consideration. Rather it was to squeeze TV, the reliable cash cow of Season 1, with 80 per cent of the telecast revenues going to the eight franchisees—last year, each team had got Rs 27 crore.

Last year IPL's Super Bowl success was largely due to what media analyst Samir Kale calls the "cricket plus" effect. It was a first-time experience for the country, the format was perfectly timed, it had glossy guys and glamorous girls, and was scheduled just right, at prime time. This year, the change in venue, according to Mindshare's Gowthaman Ragotthaman will cause a 15 per cent drop in ratings because of lack of local following. As evidence, he points to a Mindshare-Synovate study last year in which 41 per cent said the primary reason for watching IPL was "city loyalty". Well, that city will now have to be somewhere in South Africa.

by Kaveree Bamzai